

Abstract Expressionism

The Beginning of a New Chapter



Number One, 1950 | Lavender Mist
Jackson Pollock

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NOTE BY CHAIRPERSON EMERITUS

The success of a nation depends on its commitment towards knowledge and pioneering innovation. Education is a basic prerequisite, which can significantly transform and uplift the lives of the citizens. In the last few years, education has been a global focus. I have always believed in Business for Good. Thus, at Histare, our contribution to this mission thrives through Histare Office of Research and Advisory - where a team of professionals works tirelessly to better the knowledge that the generations ahead would learn from and create a better world. I believe India of tomorrow could lead the world in innovation and cutting edge studies to find solutions to some of the most complex problems. Histare Group with all its knowledge, experience, and resolve will play a significant role in it. I congratulate the team for its determination, passion, and focus. I am certain that these efforts will continue contributing to the nation's promising growth story.

Simran Wahi Vadehra
Chairperson Emeritus
The Histare Group

HISTARE OFFICE OF RESEARCH AND ADVISORY

This study is prepared by Histare Office of Research and Advisory's team of social professionals under the guidance of Educationalists and Analysts associated with us.

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Histare Office of Research and Advisory is an institution for the study of creative ideology and advances research with a view to promote Development in the field of creativity. We represent a broad range of disciplines. The initiative encourages Cooperation among professionals and supports the application of research findings to broaden better knowledge absorption.

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ABSTRACT EXPRESSIONISM

Abstract Expressionism, also called the 'New York School,' marks an important historical shift in the art realm. After World War II, Paris was no longer the centre of the art world. Abstract Expressionism was the first internationally celebrated art style to emerge from the American art scene, and while some people hated it, others championed it as an expression of American individualism.

Abstract art does not always have a recognisable focus. Instead, colours, forms, lines, curves, mixed media materials, textures, and the imagination of the artist are the focus and elements of the creativity shown on canvas. Its main characteristic is the **spontaneous** affirmation that the individual has through painting. It is a **non-figurative** art that does not adjust to the limits of **conventional representation**.

In simple terms, the Abstract Expressionism movement encompassed two broad groupings. These included: (1) "**action painters**" (2) "**colour-field**" painters. That said, it is not always easy to draw a precise line between these two types of Abstract Expressionism, and several artists contributed to both.

The **Abstract Expressionists** had no interest in creating recognisable images of the world we see around us. All they wanted was their canvases to reflect their own struggle to find meaning in the act of painting, in a world where any camera could show what things looked like.

JACKSON POLLOCK,
MOON-WOMAN CUTS THE
CIRCLE, 1943



MARK ROTHKO,
ORANGE AND YELLOW,
1956

HISTORY

In the 1930s, the two main art movements - namely, Regionalism and Social Realism - failed to satisfy their desire for a break with current thinking. Europe's political instability brought several fleeing Surrealists to New York City, with many of the Abstract Expressionists being influenced by the style and interests of the time. It encouraged their interest and belief in myth and shaped their understanding of painting as a separation between self-expression and the chaos.

By the late 1940's, many of the needed factors to form a new art movement were in place. In 1947, Jackson Pollock had found a new way to the drip technique, in 1948 De Kooning had a show at the Charles Egan Gallery, Barnett Newman had hit his peak and Mark Rothko began painting with multiple forms that lead to his major works and eighteen similar minded artists were a part of an exhibition of contemporary art at the Metropolitan Museum. This was the time when the movement gained its identity and purpose.



WILLEM DE KOONING,
WOMAN IN A FOREST,
1963



ROBERT MOTHERWELL,
MURAL PAINTING, NO. III,
1953

GROUPINGS

To quote Rosenberg, "not a picture but an event."

- Involves dripping of thinned paint
- Rhythmic sweeps of loaded brush
- Uses paints directly from can
- Abstract subject matter
- Huge Scale
- Characterized by the way artist conveys his inner impulses



LEE KRASNER,
SHELLFLOWER,
1947

Rothko said, "I paint big to be intimate."

- Large fields of flat, solid colour
- Highly coloured minimalism
- *Form and background and ground are one*
- Characterized to have an emotional impact on the viewer



BARNETT NEWMAN,
ONEMENT I,
1948

IMPACT

Jean-Paul Riopelle first introduced Abstract Expressionism to Europe in Paris in the 1950s. Two years later art curator Michel Tapié's groundbreaking book "Un Art Autre" was enormously influential in promoting the movement in Europe. Tapié promoted the works of Pollock and Hans Hoffman in exhibitions across Europe.

By the 1960s the movement's initial affect had been assimilated, yet its methods and proponents remained highly influential in art, affecting profoundly the work of many artists who followed. All the art movements of the 1960s (Tachisme, Color Field painting, Lyrical Abstraction, Fluxus, Pop Art, Minimalism, Postminimalism, Neo-expressionism) would be influenced by Abstract Expressionism.

In the wake of Abstract Expressionism, new generations of artists—both American and European—were profoundly marked by the breakthroughs made by the first generation, and went on to create their own important expressions based on, but not imitative of, those who forged the way.



JACKSON POLLOCK, MURAL UNIVERSITY OF IOWA, 1943

SUMMARY

Abstract Expressionism brought about more than depiction of a real life scene to the table. It brought emotions that do not need any real structure or form. It simply allowed the painters to take to the canvas and let out all that they felt in colours, forms, lines, curves, textures and anything else that they wanted. After the war, the painters were brimming with questions, questions that could only be answered by their own psyche. And with the new techniques of action and colour field paintings, the abstract art and expressions were combined. The spontaneity and the sense of adventure that was encouraged, to this day, has been the basis of modern art, including sculptures and architecture.

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